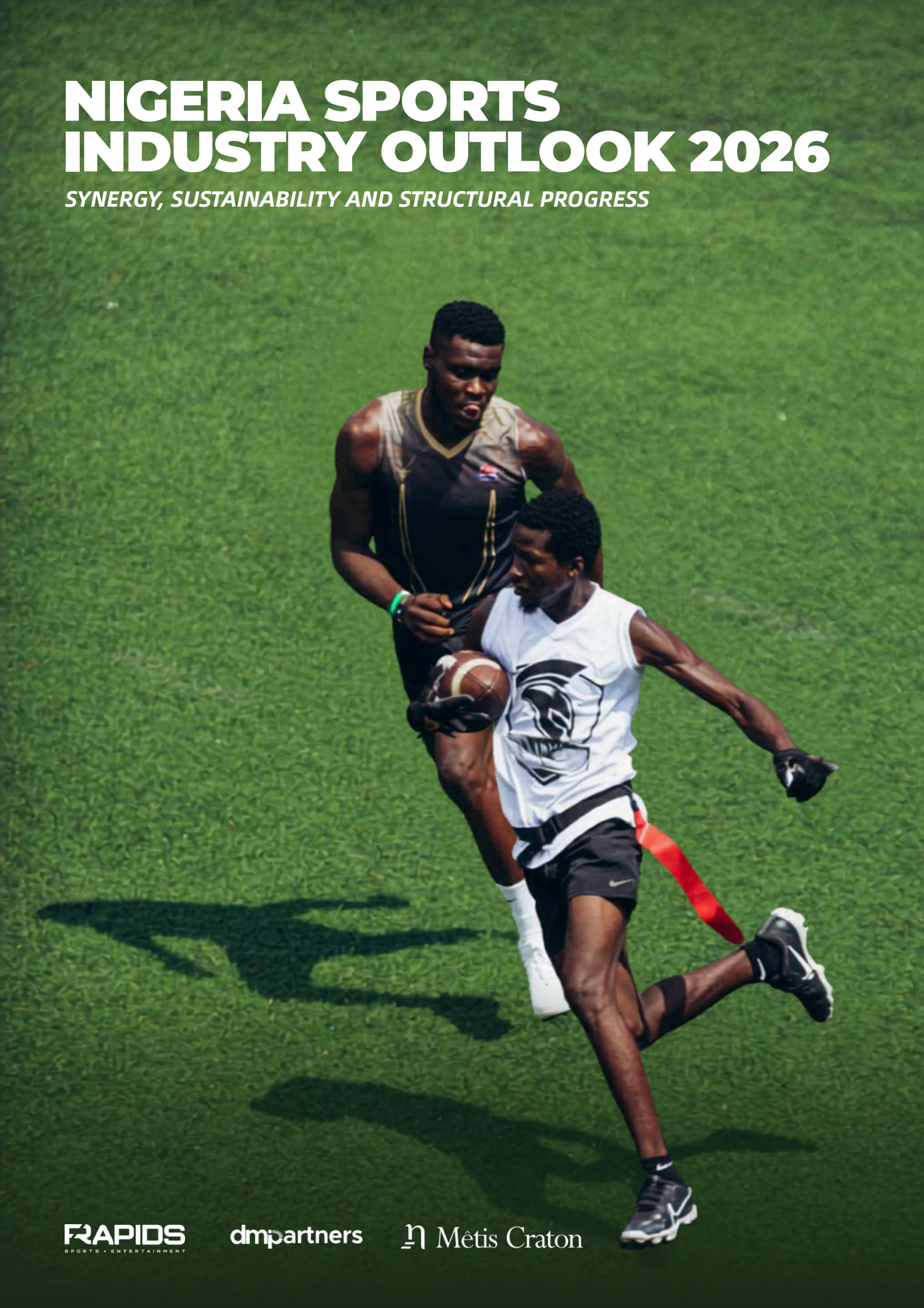
NIGERIA SPORTS INDUSTRY OUTLOOK 2026

SYNERGY, SUSTAINABILITY AND STRUCTURAL PROGRESS



RAPIDS SPORTS + ENTERTAINMENT dmpartners Métis Craton

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INTRODUCTION



Tonte Davies
Rapids Sports & Entertainment

Overview

With over 70% of Nigeria's population under the age of 35 years, sports represents one of the country's most powerful and underleveraged economic opportunities despite its recognition as a business sector of the Nigerian economy in 2020. From grassroots participation to elite competition and media consumption, the scale of Nigeria's youth market positions sports as a high-growth sector for investment, job creation, and long-term value. As sports continues to intersect with youth development, national identity, economic diversification, and private enterprise, there is a growing need for credible insights. The Nigeria Sports Industry Outlook 2026 (a first of its kind) is designed as a strategic intelligence report and reference document for investors, policymakers, business leaders, and practitioners seeking to understand where capital, partnerships, and innovation can unlock sustainable returns across the sports value chain.

This Outlook examines five critical pillars that are central to the growth and long-term development of the Nigerian sports industry: Governance, Policy and Regulations; Sporting Events; Partnerships and Investments; Licensing, IP and Merchandising; and Sports Infrastructure. Together, these sectors influence how sports is organised, funded, commercialised, regulated, and consumed across the country. Decisions made within these areas in 2026 will have significant implications for participation, performance, revenue generation, and sustainability.

To ensure depth, market-relevant insights, and practical value, the report is enriched with insights from industry experts and operators drawn from each of the five sectors. Their perspectives reflect real-world experience, current market conditions, emerging trends, investment and policy gaps, and forward-looking analysis, making this Outlook a robust resource for reference throughout 2026. By consolidating expert opinion with sector-specific trends, the Nigerian Sports Industry Outlook 2026 aims to serve as a guiding tool for shaping policy, driving investment, and strengthening the business of sports in Nigeria.

Our hope is that the practical insights provided across the pages of this report, is a simple lens that shows where things stand in the industry right now and where things can be in the year(s) ahead.



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Executive Summary

The Sports Outlook Report samples the opinion of stakeholders across key sectors in the sports industry in Nigeria - Governance, Policy and Regulations; Sporting Events; Infrastructure; Licensing, IP and Merchandise; Broadcast and Media; and Partnerships and Investment. We asked them for a review of the past year in sports in Nigeria and moments that defined the year. We asked them for what they are excited about the most and which shifts they predict will have a major impact in the new year. We asked them to define what success would look like in sports in the country.

A Review of 2025

There were many memorable events that shaped sports in 2025. As regards regulations and policy, the signing of the anti-doping bill by President Bola Tinubu and the establishment of the anti-doping commission were highlighted as significant events that shaped 2025. The Sports Africa Investment Summit (SAIS) organised by Sport Nigeria stood out as a major event that brough critical stakeholders together to discuss driving investment into the industry.

The emergence of more FG and State-led sporting assets signaled a growing sub-national investment in globally relevant sporting properties. It demonstrated an increasing recognition of sporting events as tools for economic stimulation, youth empowerment, tourism and global visibility. Our sporting events are now delivering experiences that attract players, fans, brands and partners beyond Nigeria.

As a result of the experience delivery by our events, we witnessed a recognized evolution in the partnership between brands and sporting events. Corporate brands are reportedly moving from sponsorship to long term integration and storytelling.

Overall, 2025 was seen as the year Nigerian sport began exercising real, measurable soft power globally – not just through wins, but through influence.

Defining Moments for Sports in Nigeria in 2025

Some of the reported defining moments in 2025 are as follows:

> The formal inauguration of the eSports Federation of Nigeria (NeSF) Board in February 2025. This was the moment the National Sports Commission officially acknowledged esports and its verticals as a legitimate driver of future economic value.

> The acquisition of South Africa's Multichoice Group to French Media giant, Canal+ and its effect of broadcast of Sport content on the continent.

The Super Falcons' WAFCON campaign, supported by consistent nationwide media storytelling, fundamentally changed the narrative around women's football in Nigeria.

The widespread acceptance of storytelling, brand integration, and experiential design as core components of sports events rather than peripheral additions.

Lagos hosting Africa's first All-Electric Powerboat Race - E1 Lagos GP, showcasing that global partners are seeing Nigeria as a viable partner.

Stronger eSports player representation with athletes finding their voice, organizing, and being recognized as professionals.

Expansion of the Showtime Flag Football League signaling a transition from standalone events to a sustainable league model.

Nigeria Rugby League female team wearing a locally designed and manufactured sports apparel in their first World Series Qualifiers in Canada.

Nigeria missing out of the 2026 FIFA World Cup as a dark marker on the entire sports marketing industry as brand activations, content/campaigns and media buying already count the losses in millions of dollars.

The publishing of Elusive – a story of Enyimba's consecutive Champion's League victory – by Solace Chukwu.

The increasing international appetite for African sports stories and global distribution interest in Nigerian sports IP – from scouting documentaries to behind-the-scenes football features

The launch of the NOC Safeguarding Handbook and the "SAFE SPACE" initiative at the 22nd National Sports Festival (Gateway Games) in Ogun State.

Carven becoming central to the esports and gaming ecosystem, giving players the tools to perform at higher levels.

Deeper engagement between clubs and State institutions, particularly legislatures and ministries, reflecting a growing understanding of football as a development and economic tool.

Celebrating the 25th MILO Basketball Championship reaffirming how purpose-led platforms can drive access, inclusion, and life skills development for children and youth across gender, geography, and ability levels.

The Year 2026 – Expectations and Predictions.

There is a growing awareness that sport is not just competition and a growing shift from "hosting events" to building sports properties and experiences. There is also a growing awareness that sport is not just competition.

In 2026, stakeholders predict that:

We will see increased introduction of technology, data, and fan engagement tactics across sports events.

Nigeria's performance at the 2026 IFAF Flag Football World Championship will drive youth and women's participation in flag football.

Sports apparel and fashion will play a significant role in connecting young people to sports than the actual sporting events.

More Nigerian athletes will transition into structured content ventures – podcasts, documentaries, and equity-backed media projects.

Gaming will move from a subculture to a pillar of mainstream Nigerian media, fueled by more consistent TV programming and celebrity involvement.

There will be heightened scrutiny of sports federations' governance structures, especially where public funds and private sponsorship intersect.

More Nigerian athletes will demand standardised contracts and professional representation.

The NSC and NOC will begin requiring all sports federations to have certified Safeguarding Officers as a prerequisite for federal funding.

Women's football will move from symbolic inclusion to real investment, including clearer ownership structures and competitive frameworks.

There will be stronger institutional support for structured grassroots platforms, deeper school-community collaborations, and clearer frameworks for measuring inclusion and long-term impact.

We will have expanded focus on stadium experience, safety, and technology, including LED boards, ticketing systems, and volunteer/steward development.

Brand participation will continue to evolve, with sponsors playing more strategic roles in shaping event narratives, experiences, and cultural relevance rather than simply funding visibility.

More Nigerian athletes will transition into structured content ventures – podcasts, documentaries, and equity-backed media projects.



What Does Success Mean Going Forward?

There is a consensus that as the sports industry enters a new year, measurement of success would go beyond medals won by athletes. Success would be measured in stronger systems built to support performance, credible administration, sustained media engagement through stories told and stories preserved, increased private-sector confidence and global respect earned. Success will be measured by how well the industry converts ambition into structure, and structure into long-term value.

A successful 2026 is one where Nigerian sports ecosystem is organized, commercially viable, youth-focused, and increasingly competitive on the global stage. Where there is noticeable increase in the total revenue generated from sports as a business. Where there is formal recognition of sports as an integral pillar of the entertainment economy–entitling it to the same fiscal incentives, regulatory support, and government attention already extended to Nigeria's creative industries.

This success, as imagined, will come from building systems and institutions that endure, not just creating headline moments. This means better governance, stronger commercial models, improved athlete and fan experiences, and consistency in event delivery standards. This success can only be achieved when policies support growth and there is less bureaucracy within Government institutions and National Federations, facilitating more private sector investment in the industry. The success will happen through synergy, sustainability and structural progress.

01

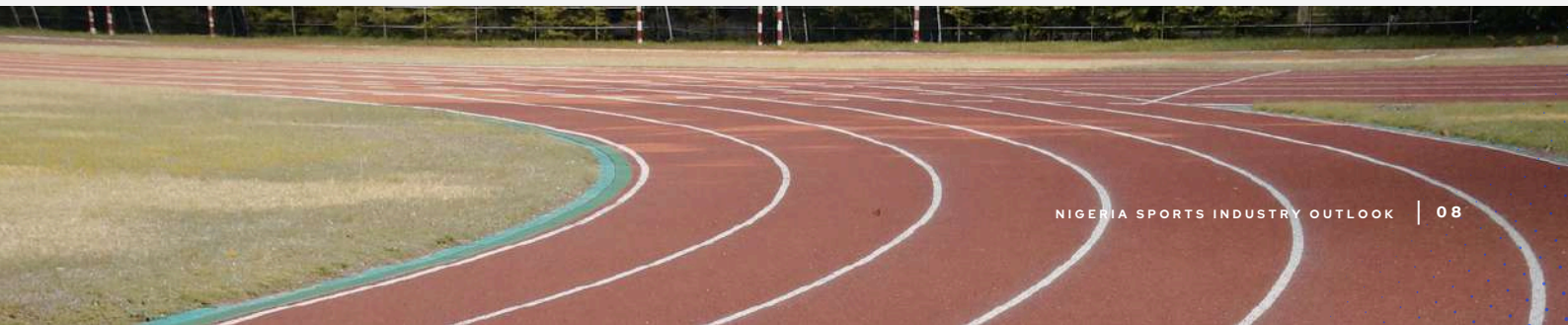
"The shift from 2025 to 2026 feels like a true inflection point. Digital-first sports have moved from the margins to the mainstream, now straddling three federal ministries–Youth & Sports Development, Communications & Digital Economy"
- **Yahaya Maikori**

02

The shift is already evident: women's sports are no longer treated as side narratives but as central assets within the sports ecosystem, capable of driving engagement, revenue, and national pride.
- **Debbie Izamoje-Okolie**

03

A critical legislative victory was the passage of the Anti-Doping Bill and the establishment of the National Anti-Doping Commission, which restored Nigeria's full compliance and global credibility with WADA.
- **Femi Abioye**





SPOTLIGHT ON KEY SECTORS WITHIN NIGERIA'S SPORTS INDUSTRY



Telema Davies
Managing Partner, DMPartners.



Adedamilola Adedotun
Head of Sports, The Temple Company

Executive Snapshot

According to the World Economic Forum, sport is a key driver of the global economy. It currently generates $2.3 trillion in total annual revenues and is projected to grow at a compounded rate of 10% over the next five years. Forecast puts sport at $3.7 trillion by 2030 by 2030, and $8.8 trillion by 2050.

Nigeria' sports industry is in its emerging phase, acknowledged as a strategic economic and social driver, and underpinned by infrastructure, media, technology and commerce. Target investment in modern infrastructure, events, digital content, and sponsorship could unlock ₦2–₦4trillion ($1.4bn - $2.8bn) in revenue over the next decade. The revenue will be delivered primarily through professional and elite sports, mass participation and physical activities, sporting goods and services.

Integrated value-chain development will ensure progress in one sector amplifies growth across others, while digital platforms and e-sports will help in expanding audience engagement. With clear public and private-sector collaboration, sport is poised to become a major contributor to Nigeria's economic diversification and youth-driven growth.

$3.7T
Projected value by 2030

₦2–₦4T
Nigeria's potential sports revenue in 10 years

Sector Overview

This outlook highlights priority sectors within Nigeria's sports industry, selected for their economic impact, growth potential, and ability to drive development across the broader industry value chain. We believe these sectors are fundamental to creating the sport product and unlocking the revenue potentials there. Governance and policies, investment and partnerships, sport infrastructure, events, media and content, and technology-enabled commerce, have been identified as critical levers for industry transformation.

Government policies and regulations are fundamental to the development of sports as they act as blueprint that guides institutional stability. The 2022 – 2026 National Sports Industry Policy (NSIP) shifts the focus from purely recreational sports to a business-oriented sports industry. It aims to achieve this through private sector incentives-backed investment in infrastructure. The current administration's approach to transform sports with the Renewed Hope Agenda is through infrastructure rehabilitation, private sector investment, international competitions, and athlete welfare.

In addition to government funding, infrastructure funds, football funds and other private funds as well as corporate organisation will provide the investment and sponsorship needed for the transformation and growth of the sports industry. Global private investment in sports is led by private equity (PE) firms, sovereign wealth funds, and investors seeking returns; while corporate organisations are fueling global sponsorships approaching US$150billion by 2034

Sports infrastructure and facilities for mass participation, talent development and events, form the foundation of the industry. Investments in venues like the Remo Stars Stadium and the proposed 12,000-capacity Lagos Arena signal a shift toward commercial-grade facilities capable of hosting major events. Policy analyses suggest that sustained infrastructure investment of US$500million annually could generate N2trillion in revenues over the next decade, highlighting both opportunity and scale.

Key Takeaways

Strategic Focus
Infrastructure, media, technology, and commerce are critical growth levers.

Economic impact
The sports sector could generate ₦2 - ₦4 trillion over the next decade with sustained investment.

Growth drivers
Digital media, e-sports, and sponsorships are accelerating revenue diversification.

Value chain synergy
Progress in one sector strengthens the entire ecosystem.

Forward-looking
Policy support, private-sector partnerships, and professional governance will be pivotal to positioning sports as a core contributor to Nigeria's economic diversification.



Sector Highlights

Sector	Role in Value Chain	Key Benchmark / Data	Emerging Trends
Infrastructure & Facilities	Foundation for leagues, athlete development, events	US$500M annual investment → N2T revenue potential	Modern arenas, public-private partnerships
Media & Content	Visibility, monetization	US$116-$118M projected revenue (2026)	Digital streaming, broadcast expansion
Sports Equipment, Retail & Technology	Performance, fan engagement, analytics	Sports retail market: US$1.6B	E-sports growth, digital platforms
Commerce & Sponsorship	Monetization, brand integration	Market potential: ₦2T (~US$4.4B)	Corporate partnerships, merchandising, licensing





SECTOR INSIGHT

GOVERNANCE, POLICY AND REGULATIONS

Overview

The trajectory of Nigeria's sports industry over the next decade will be defined by compliance of the administrative core in adherence to governance, policy, and regulatory compliance. As the sector transitions from a federation-led administrative model to a commercially viable ecosystem, regulatory clarity and institutional reforms are becoming critical enablers of growth. The introduction of the National Sports Industry Policy signaled a strategic shift toward private sector participation, structured investment frameworks, and improved accountability standards. However, policy momentum must now translate into implementation, enforcement discipline, transparent governance within national federations, and bankable regulatory environments that reduce investor risk.

In 2026 and beyond, competitiveness will depend not only on talent output but on governance quality – compliance systems, dispute resolution mechanisms, financial transparency, and performance-based funding models. For Nigeria to position sport as a credible economic sector, reform must move from policy articulation to measurable institutional execution. Governance is no longer administrative overhead; it is core infrastructure for industry growth.

Panelists

01

Yahaya Maikori – President, Nigeria Esport Federation (NeSF)

With renewed momentum, NeSF will drive professionalisation across the value chain–players, event promoters, casters, coaches, and service providers–through targeted advocacy with global publishers, investors, relevant MDAs, and international federations.

Beverley Agbakoba-Onyejianya – Partner, Olisa Agbakoba Legal (OAL)

The government dismantling its red tape to make things work will make a successful year in 2026. Because, in reality, the government is holding a lot of beautiful things down with bureaucracy.

02

03

Femi Abioye – CEO, Dekaizen Worldwide Ltd

2025 was defined by balanced success on the field and in governance reforms: winning titles while ensuring athlete safety and integrity. For 2026, success will mean embedding safeguarding into every level of the sports ecosystem, ensuring that Nigeria's athletic triumphs are matched by safe, transparent, and inclusive environments for all stakeholders.

Yahaya Maikori

As a thought partner and key stakeholder deeply embedded in Nigeria's esports –shaping it from both local and international boardrooms –I am excited to share my perspective on the 2026 Sports Industry Outlook.

The shift from 2025 to 2026 feels like a true inflection point. Digital-first sports have moved from the margins to the mainstream, now straddling three federal ministries–Youth & Sports Development, Communications & Digital Economy. This has enhanced its structured integration into Nigeria's economic and entertainment fabric.

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

The institutionalization of digital sports. After years of operating in silos, 2025 marked the arrival of a genuine "One Sports" philosophy. The National Sports Commission began treating digital athletes with the same seriousness as their traditional counterparts. Recognition became policy, and policy became possibility.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

- *The formal inauguration of the eSports Federation of Nigeria (NeSF) Board in February 2025. This was the moment the National Sports Commission officially acknowledged esports and its verticals as a legitimate driver of future economic value. Overnight, the industry gained a unified voice and stakeholders–local and international–gained the confidence to commit capital to the Nigerian market.*
- *The historic debut of esports at the National Sports Festival ("Gateway Games") in Ogun State. By placing esports on a national stage, we effectively democratised the discipline, shifting it from private passion to public pride.*

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

The National Sports Commission has, as a policy, decided to work with federations to drive the creation of local sports franchise events that can bring commercial value to the country. This promises to be a gamer changer especially in a challenged industry struggling with impactful sponsorship.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area in 2026?

- *With renewed momentum, NeSF will drive professionalisation across the value chain–players, event promoters, casters, coaches, and service providers–through targeted advocacy with global publishers, investors, relevant MDAs, and international federations.*
- *The launch of the Nigeria Esports League in Q2 2026 will inject structured local competition, unlock new sponsorship pools, and catalyse fresh investment inflows.*
- *We shall see impactful investments in esports – these shall include purpose built digital venues and the hosting of regional competitions outside of Lagos and Abuja creating professional pathways for local talent.*

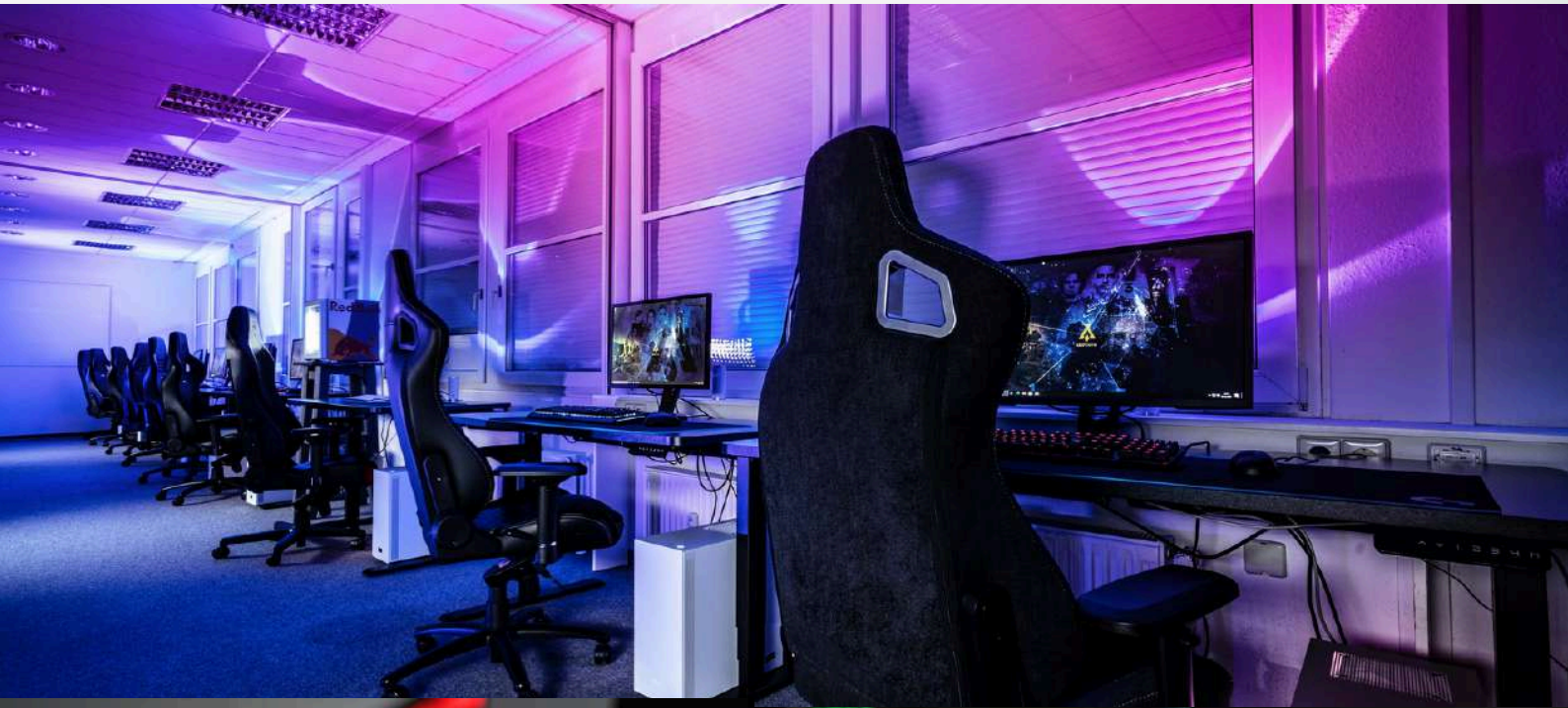
5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

Success in 2026 will be measured by policy harmonisation and decisive implementation:

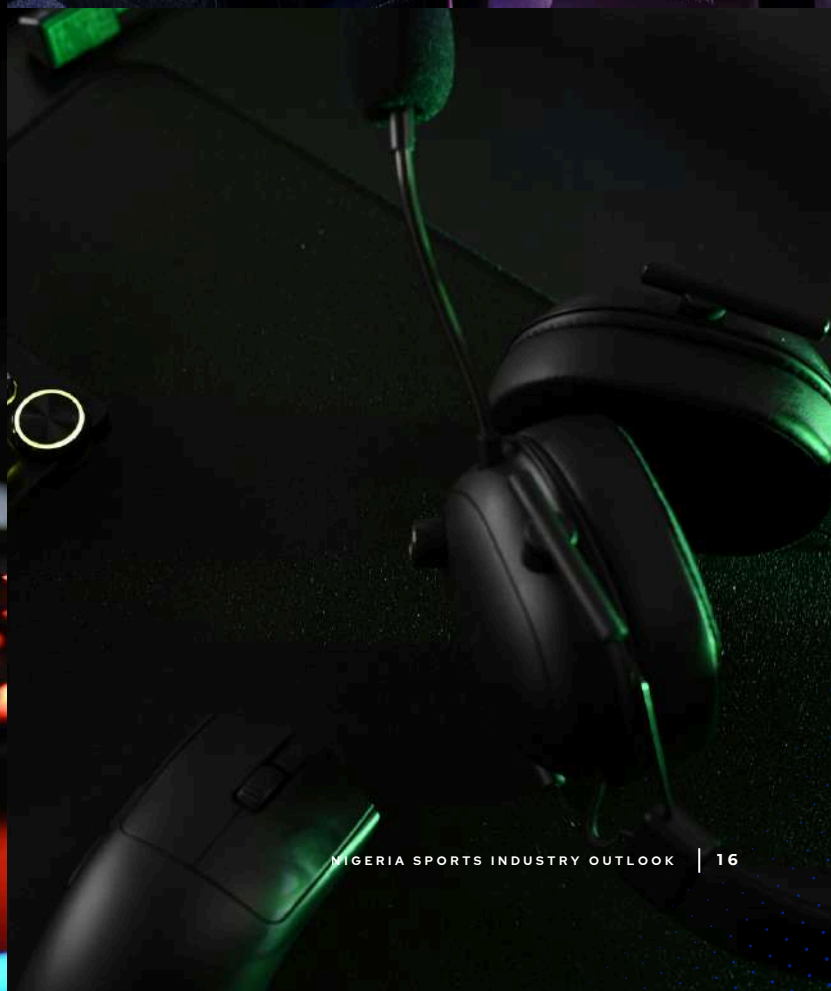
- *Full operationalisation of the National Sports Industry Policy (NSIP), creating clear incentives for private-sector investment to close the infrastructure gap.*
- *Permanent integration of esports as a medal event at the 2026 National Sports Festival and beyond.*

- *Formal recognition of sports as an integral pillar of the entertainment economy—entitling it to the same fiscal incentives, regulatory support, and government attention already extended to Nigeria's creative industries.*

From my vantage point—bridging African opportunity with global best practice—these developments are not just milestones; they are the foundation of a multi-billion-dollar industry that will create jobs, drive innovation, and put Nigeria firmly on the global esports map. 2026 is the year we stop talking about potential and start counting value.







Beverley Agbakoba-Onyejianya





Key Highlights of the Nigerian Sports Industry in 2025

In 2025, Nigeria's sports industry achieved significant progress as part of broader efforts to strengthen governance, promote integrity, and enhance its commercial potential. One of the most notable events was the signing of the Nigeria Anti-Doping Act 2025 by President Bola Tinubu. This legislation aligns Nigeria with the World Anti-Doping Code and international standards.

Additionally, there was a marked increase in the proactive assertion of rights by Nigerian athletes and stakeholders through arbitration and the courts. A landmark ruling by the National Industrial Court exemplified this trend, as football authorities and a club were held accountable and ordered to pay compensation to the family of a late player for breaching their duty of care.

Defining Moments for the Sector in 2025

A defining moment for the industry was the signing of the Nigeria Anti-Doping Act 2025 by President Bola Tinubu. After nearly two decades in development, this law finally brings Nigeria in line with the World Anti-Doping Code and international standards. It has also paved the way for establishing the first independent National Anti-Doping Agency, bringing it on par with Kenya, which has its ADAK anti-doping agency of Kenya. This is a significant step toward restoring credibility and protecting the integrity of Nigerian sports.

The strengthened National Sports Commission continued to drive the Renewed Hope Initiative for Nigeria's Sports Economy (RHINSE), focusing on better governance, transparency, and sustainable funding.

In terms of dispute resolution, Nigerian sports stakeholders became more assertive in claiming their rights. A notable case was the National Industrial Court's ruling that held a club, league officials, and the federation accountable for breaching their duty of care in a player welfare matter. This ruling sent a strong message that governing bodies and clubs can be held responsible when basic safety and welfare standards are not upheld.

1. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

There is a strong shift toward treating sports as a serious commercial sector, which means we should expect more sophisticated multi-party contracts, investment structures, and greater legal protections and enforcement for stakeholders. Athlete rights are becoming more prominent, with players and coaches more willing to enforce contracts and challenge unfair practices.

I am also very excited about the decentralisation of quality sports business education and programmes delivered and offered for Africans by Africans, offered through the Business of Sports Institute Africa (BOS). It remains undisputed that the primary way to develop any sector or industry is through capacity building and education. BOS intends to make its mark Africa-wide where sports business education is concerned.

2. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

In 2026, one of the key developments expected to have a significant impact on Nigeria's sports landscape is the full implementation of the Nigeria Tax Act 2025, which took effect from January 2026. This will introduce clearer and more structured rules governing the taxation of income for sports stakeholders and sports organisations, covering salaries, endorsements, prize money, sponsorship agreements, and the rapidly growing sports betting sector. This should encourage better tax structuring, transparency, and reduced multiple taxation issues that have hindered commercialisation.

We eagerly expect growing emphasis on administrative reforms and professionalism, and increased focus on efficient dispute resolution, athlete representation, and standardised contracts. These are key pillars of the sports business sector.

Overall, 2026 feels like a pivotal year where sports law moves from addressing crises to actively shaping a more professional, investor-friendly, and athlete-centred industry. Implementation will be key, but the direction is encouraging.

3. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

A successful year for the sports industry in 2026 would be marked by the tangible translation of recent reforms into measurable stability, integrity, and commercial growth.

It would mean the Nigeria Anti-Doping Agency is fully operational with its board actively driving compliance, testing, and education, reinforcing our alignment with the World Anti-Doping Code, restoring full international credibility, and positioning Nigeria as a potential regional hub through the planned WADA-accredited laboratory.

Success would also show in the effective implementation of the funding reset. Timely and unified budgetary releases under the strengthened National Sports Commission (NSC), as part of the Renewed Hope Initiative for Nigeria's Sports Economy (RHINSE), would reduce funding-related disputes, enable smoother sponsorship and public-private partnership contracts, and support infrastructure development and athlete welfare without the usual delays.

On the taxation front, a successful outcome would be improved tax structuring and compliance that minimises multiple taxation issues while encouraging legitimate investment and commercialisation, rather than creating new bottlenecks. Beyond these, a strong year would feature fewer federation-level crises, greater use of efficient dispute resolution mechanisms (including arbitration), more standardised athlete and player contracts with better welfare protections, and visible progress in governance reforms that promote independence and professionalism.

In essence, 2026 would feel successful if the industry moves from reactive crisis management to proactive shaping of a more structured, investor-friendly, and athlete-centred ecosystem, with rising private investment, reduced disputes, and sports contributing even more visibly to job creation and economic value.

Femi Abioye

As a sports insurance expert and IOC-certified safeguarding officer, I am pleased to share an evidence-based perspective tailored to my administrative role in governance and safe sport outlook on the Nigerian sports landscape. The year 2025 marked a pivotal structural shift, moving the nation from a competition-centric focus toward a regulated, integrity-driven sports economy.

The following insights document the progress of 2025 and our strategic expectations for 2026:

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

The hallmark of 2025 was the institutional revitalization of the National Sports Commission (NSC) under the Renewed Hope Initiative for Nigerian Sports Economy (RHINSE). This transition successfully repositioned sports as a national economic asset rather than just a recreational activity. A critical legislative victory was the passage of the Anti-Doping Bill and the establishment of the National Anti-Doping Commission, which restored Nigeria's full compliance and global credibility with WADA. Additionally, 2025 saw the rise of "emerging" sports like flag football and cricket, signaling a healthy diversification of the industry beyond football.

Lastly, governance reforms initiated by the National Sports Commission (NSC) underscored transparency and bolstered private-sector confidence, signalling a transition toward sustainable sports development.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

Heightened awareness surrounding athlete welfare and safeguarding policies, with federations commencing the adoption of IOC-aligned frameworks. With Public discourse on the prevention of harassment and abuse gained momentum, compelling administrators to prioritize the establishment of secure environments.

The sector witnessed a landmark shift with the launch of the NOC Safeguarding Handbook and the "SAFE SPACE" initiative at the 22nd National Sports Festival (Gateway Games) in Ogun State. This introduced a comprehensive framework for mental health and athlete protection. Furthermore, the NSC's "Athletes First" objective institutionalized elite training grants and welfare reforms, ensuring that athlete support is proactive rather than reactive.

The introduction of Chief Operating Officers (COOs) across various federations has also significantly professionalized internal governance and transparency. *This Improved transparency and relative stability surrounding numerous sports federation elections, which alleviated some governance tensions and fostered a more conducive environment for advancing safeguarding standards and codes of conduct.*

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigeria sports industry in 2026?

I am particularly excited about the tangible growth of the "Sports as Business" model. In 2025, we successfully galvanized an estimated ₦50 billion in private sector investment, and I anticipate this trajectory will accelerate in 2026.

The industry is also on the verge of a digital governance revolution, where tools for monitoring compliance and reporting safeguarding breaches will become standard. I am also keen to see how our increased GDP contribution—now exceeding 1%—will attract further institutional investors into the sports academy and grassroots infrastructure space.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

- ***Mandatory Safeguarding Audits:*** *I predict that the NSC and NOC will begin requiring all sports federations to have certified Safeguarding Officers as a prerequisite for federal funding.*
- ***Infrastructure Concessions:*** *We expect to see the commencement of private-sector-led renovations for major national stadiums to meet global standards.*
- ***International Compliance:*** *As Nigeria prepares for various 2026 World Championships and other global qualifiers, our focus will shift toward strict adherence to international safeguarding and anti-doping protocols.*
- ***Talent Verification:*** *A significant shift toward using digital identity systems (like NIN integration) to eliminate age cheating and protect the integrity of youth competitions.*

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

A successful 2026 for the Nigerian sports ecosystem would be characterized by:

- ***Zero Major Integrity Breaches:*** *No significant safeguarding or doping scandals during major international outings, proving the efficacy of our newly established Safe Sports commissions under the Nigeria Olympic Committee (NOC).*
- ***Increased Private Sector Investments:*** *Surpassing the 2025 investment figures, with sports becoming a more robust contributor to the national economy.*
- ***Elite Performance Stability:*** *Consistent podium finishes across varied disciplines, supported by the continued rollout of the "Athletes First" welfare and grant schemes.*

This framework ensures that our industry is built on a foundation of safety, professional governance, and economic sustainability. In summary, 2025 was defined by balanced success on the field and in governance reforms: winning titles while ensuring athlete safety and integrity.

For 2026, success will mean embedding safeguarding into every level of the sports ecosystem, ensuring that Nigeria's athletic triumphs are matched by safe, transparent, and inclusive environments for all stakeholders.







SECTOR INSIGHT

SPORTING EVENTS

Overview

The events sector is a critical growth engine within the global sports industry including Nigeria, which serves as the primary vehicle for participation, talent discovery, commercial engagement, and community development. From grassroots competitions and city marathons/races to professional league fixtures like the Nigeria Premier Football League (NPFL), flagship tournaments such as the National Sports Festival to international events like the E1 Lagos series, sporting events drive sponsorship investment, media attention, local and international tourism, and youth engagement across the country.

In a market where structured sports infrastructure is still evolving, events provide immediate platforms for brands, Government, and private organisers to activate partnerships, stimulate local economies, and build fan communities. As Nigeria's youth population expands and corporate interest in sports marketing deepens, the events segment stands out as one of the most commercially viable and socially impactful pillars shaping the outlook of the nation's sports industry.

Panelists

01 Yetunde Olopade – MD, Nilayo Sports

02 Adeyemi Adesanya – Sports Marketing Manager – Red Bull

03 Damilola Pedro – COO, Gamr Africa (GamrX)

04 Adejare Adejumo – Commissioner, Showtime Flag Football

05 Kunmi Adenipebi – Founder, Game Evolution Partners

Key Highlights

01

There is a growing awareness that sport is not just competition. It is content, culture, business, tourism, and community. We are seeing stronger intent around innovation, improved production quality, and more deliberate collaboration between sporting events organizers, brands, and government stakeholders

– **Yetunde Olopade**

02

We will see a shift from just hosting games to matchday experiences. An increase in the number of privately owned clubs is leading to better curation of matches and a keen focus on scaling the fan experience

– Adeyemi Adesanya

03

When the government provides the 'enabling environment'–through high-speed internet infrastructure and tax incentives for tech-sports–and the private sector provides the content and talent, the entire sports industry wins

– Kunmi Adenipebi

04

We are beginning to see the rise of multi-state competitions that bring amateur and pro players together. And in these moments, we see creativity and storylines forming, proofs that when platforms and preparations meet, real competitive standards emerge making the sport feel alive.

– Damilola Pedro

05

Nigeria is entering 2026 with a credible global pathway in flag football. Continental dominance combined with World Championship qualification creates new opportunities for sponsorship, youth participation, diaspora engagement, and long-term sports business development

– Adejumo Adejare.

Yetunde Olopade

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

Key highlights in Nigeria's sports industry in 2025 included the emergence of more state-led sporting assets, significantly broadening the national and continental sports calendar. Notably, Enugu State made a strong statement with the introduction of the Enugu City International Marathon, signaling growing sub-national investment in globally relevant sporting properties.

Equally significant was the world-class National Sports Festival hosted by the Ogun State Government, which further positioned Ogun State as an evolving hub for major sporting events and destination-driven competitions and the Niger-Delta Sports Festival too. Across the country, we witnessed a shift where states and institutions increasingly recognized sports events as tools for economic stimulation, youth empowerment, tourism development, and global visibility. Private organizations, including Nilayo Sports Management Limited, continued to play a pivotal role in driving this momentum through innovation, professional delivery, and strategic partnerships.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

"Brands are no longer just sponsors - they are co-architects of the event experience."

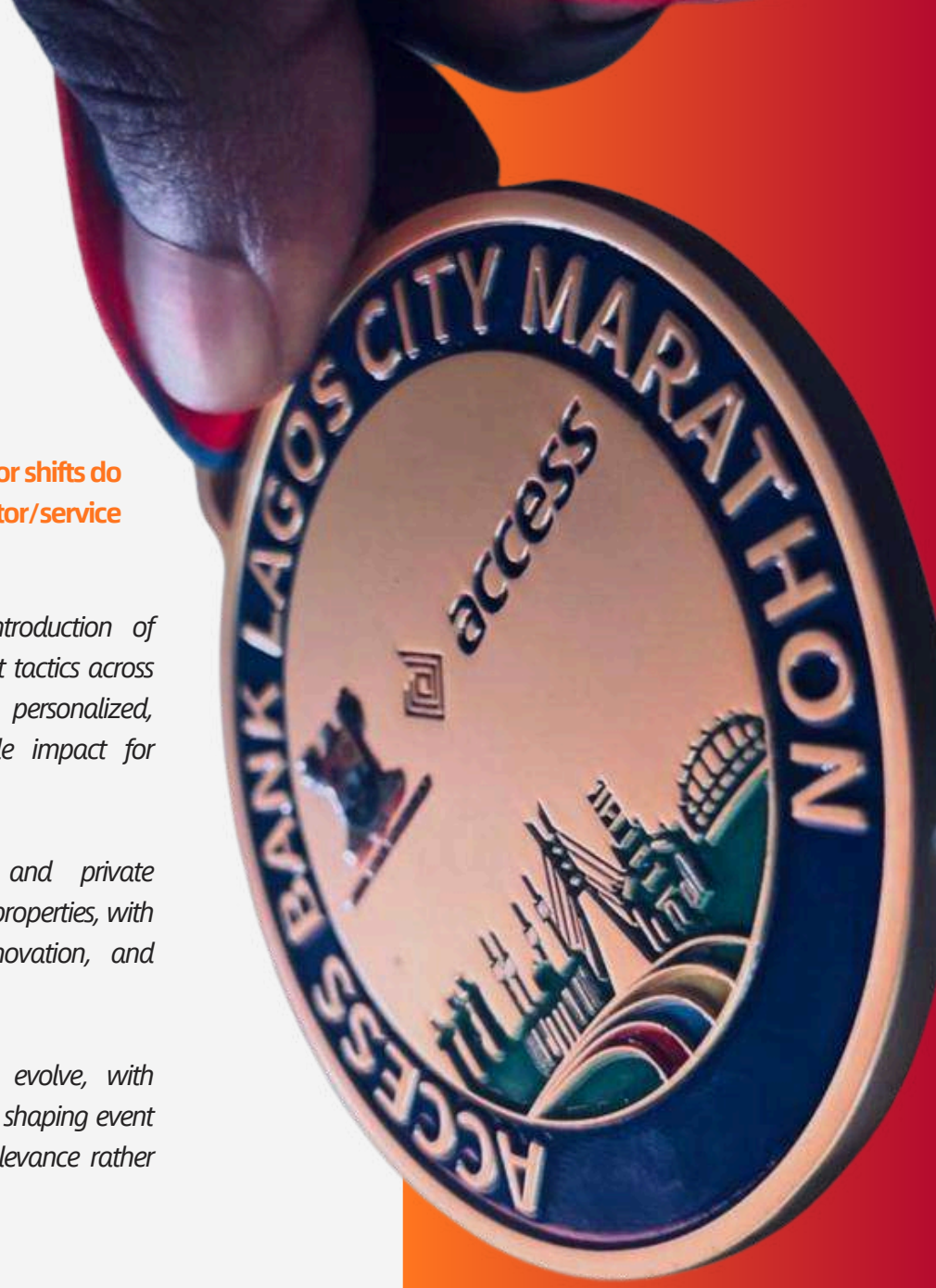
For the sports events and experiential marketing sector, 2025 marked a decisive shift in how events are conceptualized and delivered.

One of the most defining developments was the widespread acceptance of storytelling, brand integration, and experiential design as core components of sports events rather than peripheral additions. Brands no longer approached events simply as sponsorship platforms for logo visibility or advertising placements; they became active collaborators in the planning and creative process.

This has given rise to more immersive event environments, characterized by innovative, audience-centric activations that enhanced both fan engagement and brand relevance. The focus moved from passive exposure to meaningful interaction and shared experiences. In essence, 2025 reinforced a new reality: successful sports events are now built at the intersection of sport, entertainment, culture, and brand storytelling.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

What excites me most is the clear shift from "hosting events" to building sports properties and experiences. There is a growing awareness that sport is not just competition. It is content, culture, business, tourism, and community. We are seeing stronger intent around innovation, improved production quality, and more deliberate collaboration between sporting events organizers, brands, and government stakeholders. This signals an industry that is maturing and beginning to understand the long-term value of well-structured sporting assets.



4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area in 2026?

In 2026, I expect to see more introduction of technology, data, and fan engagement tactics across sports events. The focus will be on personalized, audience experience, and measurable impact for partners.

We should expect more states and private organizations launching more sporting properties, with stronger competition for quality, innovation, and global relevance.

Brand participation will continue to evolve, with sponsors playing more strategic roles in shaping event narratives, experiences, and cultural relevance rather than simply funding visibility.

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

A successful 2026 would be defined by sustainability and structural progress. This means better governance, stronger commercial models, improved athlete and fan experiences, and consistency in event delivery standards. Success will come from building systems and institutions that endure, not just creating headline moments. Ultimately, progress will be measured by how well the industry converts ambition into structure, and structure into long-term value.

"The future of sports in Nigeria is ecosystem-driven, not event-driven."

Adeyemi Adesanya

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

The AFCON 2025 Bronze (Morocco). I believe the tournament made Nigerians love the Super Eagles again especially after the ill-fated World Cup qualification campaign.

Tobi Amusan's Silver at the World Athletics Championship. Great bounce back after the Olympics and drug related misfortune

The emergence of lesser [followed] sports like Scrabble getting some of the limelight.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

A major shift from a broadcast perspective as the door has been opened to Content creators from an accreditation and rights standpoint.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigeria sports industry in 2026?

The Rise of "Alternative" Sports Culture: beyond football, we are seeing traction in lifestyle sports. The success of events like Red Bull Encouraged (BMX); the rise of Scrabble and Skateboarding, and the growth of local basketball leagues across the country suggests Gen Zs are looking for diverse entertainment. 2026 feels like the year these niche sports go mainstream.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

Red Bull Car Park Drift: This is expected to make a big statement in Motorsports

The "Fan Experience" Pivot: We will see a shift from just "hosting games" to "matchday experiences." An increase in the number of privately owned clubs is leading to better curation of matches and a keen focus on scaling the fan experience. It is hoped that this will lead to more fans heading to the stadia.

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

Policy stability and direction: The NSC surviving the political year without leadership changes. Consistency is what investors (and global brands) need to invest in a developing sporting ecosystem.

Better financial discipline;

More Competitions and events for core and mainstream sports.



Damilola Pedro

1. What were your key highlights for the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

When I look at 2025, what stands out is how far esports have come from an events and infrastructure standpoints.

GamrX hitting its fifth year was the major moment for us. It shows five years of consistency, scale, and credibility. It shows the industry is no longer experimenting, it's now delivering experiences that attract players, fans, bra
nds, and publishers beyond Nigeria. It shows GamrX has become globally relevant. We're seeing interest from players in other non-African countries, international attention, and publishers beginning to take the ecosystem here seriously. That shift matters. It positions Nigeria as a real destination for competitive gaming.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector in 2025?

We saw stronger player representation, athletes are finding their voice, organizing, and being recognized as professionals. That's a big shift for the goal. Events are becoming more competitive and more visible. GamrX and similar platforms have built credibility through consistency and delivery.

We are beginning to see the rise of multi-state competitions that bring amateur and pro players together. And in these moments, we see creativity and storylines forming, proofs that when platforms and preparations meet, real competitive standards emerge making the sport feel alive.

With structured regulations and investments, we see the esports scene becoming more relevant and professional. Leagues and tournaments are getting consistent, and players are starting to be recognized the way athletes in traditional sports are.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigeria sports industry in 2026?

The confidence.

You can feel it across the ecosystem. Players believe there's a path. Organizers understand what it takes to deliver. Partners are coming in earlier, not just observing from the sidelines. Publishers are beginning to engage directly, which is a strong signal that Nigeria is now on the global esports map. And we're starting to see Nigerian players compete with more structure, more preparation, and more belief in their place within the global scene.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

You'll see more international participation in local competitions. Not just Africans competing, but players from other countries entering the space. You'll see publishers becoming more present. Not just watching, but also engaging, supporting, and building relationships with the local ecosystem. Over the years, I've seen sponsorships and collaborations from brands that previously didn't engage with esports, which says a lot about its growth, inclusion, and professionalism.

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in Nigeria in 2026?

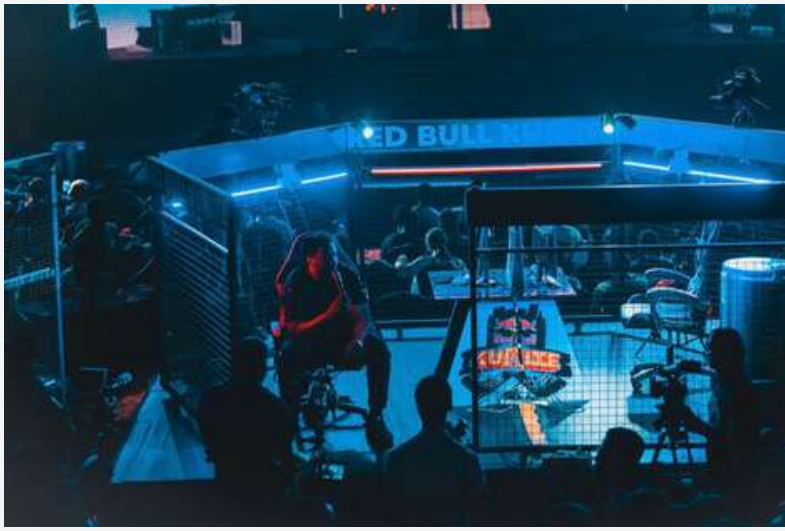
A successful year is when participation rises and performance improves at the same time.

- *When athletes have places to train at every region in Nigeria.*
- *When funding becomes more structured.*
- *When policies support growth instead of slowing it down.*
- *When Nigerian players are visible and respected beyond our borders.*
- *When national events like GamrX are consistent and well attended.*

A successful year would be one where participation grows, not just in numbers but in quality. Events run smoothly and draw global attention. Hubs and infrastructure are accessible and help develop talent consistently.

The challenges are no longer about proving esports deserves a seat at the table. That conversation has moved. Now it's about scale, it's about standards, and global competitiveness.





And with platforms like GamrX and infrastructure like Carven driving the progress, the industry is operating with more clarity, more credibility, and stronger direction than ever before.

Adejare Adejumo

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

-Nigeria's emergence as Africa's leading flag football nation: In 2025, Nigeria's men's and women's teams won the inaugural IFAF Africa Flag Football Championships in Cairo, Egypt. This double victory marked Nigeria's arrival as a continental leader in a fast-growing global sport.
- Landmark victory on foreign soil: Nigeria's narrow 13–12 win over host nation Egypt in the men's final stood out as a defining competitive moment, signaling Nigeria's ability to perform under pressure on the continental stage.
-Qualification for the 2026 IFAF Flag Football World Championships: Nigeria's success in Egypt secured qualification for the 2026 IFAF Flag Football World Championships in Düsseldorf, Germany, elevating the country's global sports profile.



2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

- ***Expansion of the Showtime Flag Football League calendar:*** *For the first time, the Showtime Flag Football League successfully structured its season around two major tournaments: the Summer Series and the Fall Series, signaling a transition from standalone events to a sustainable league model.*

- ***Establishment of a consistent competition venue:*** *The use of the Showtime Arena at Meadow Hall School, Lekki, reinforced professionalism, consistency, and improved fan experience.*

- ***Improved competition standards:*** *The league placed a deliberate focus on officiating quality, player development, and competition structure, aligning domestic play more closely with international standards.*

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigeria sports industry in 2026?

Nigeria is entering 2026 with a credible global pathway in flag football. Continental dominance combined with World Championship qualification creates new opportunities for sponsorship, youth participation, diaspora engagement, and long-term sports business development.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

- *Nigeria's performance at the 2026 IFAF Flag Football World Championships becoming a major national talking point.*
- *Growth in women's and youth participation driven by Nigeria's continental success.*
- *Increased commercialization and media packaging of domestic flag football leagues, including stronger sponsorships and content production.*

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in Nigeria in 2026?

- *More Nigerian sports achieving sustained global relevance, not just participation.*
- *Stronger league governance, improved venues, and measurable sponsor value.*
- *Clear development pathways connecting schools, leagues, and national teams.*

Overall, a successful 2026 would reflect a Nigerian sports ecosystem that is organized, commercially viable, youth-focused, and increasingly competitive on the global stage.



Kunmi Adenipebi

1. What were the key highlights for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

- *The primary highlight was the explosive growth of the EAFC community, specifically the success of the Cade Esports Pro League (Division 1). The Nigeria vs. Ghana series served as a massive proof of concept, generating phenomenal engagement metrics that prove the appetite for high-stakes regional rivalries.*

- *Beyond EAFC, we saw a significant shift in the global perception of the African market. Major developers—including those behind Free fire, PUBG Mobile, Call of Duty: Mobile, and Mobile Legends—transitioned from passive observation to active participation. Their decision to run direct, localized events in Nigeria marks a turning point where we are no longer just players, but a priority demographic for the world's biggest gaming titles.*

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

The year was defined by Institutional Legitimacy and Media Integration.

- *First, the reformation of the National Esports Federation was a watershed moment. It signalled that the Nigerian government recognizes Esports as a formal sporting discipline, providing the regulatory framework needed for long-term investment.*

- *Second, the pivot of traditional TV stations toward Esports was a gamechanger. Moving gaming content from niche digital platforms to mainstream broadcast television has begun to bridge the generational gap, bringing competitive gaming into the living rooms of millions of Nigerians.*

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigeria sports industry in 2026?

I am most excited about the maturation of brand partnerships. We are seeing international brands move beyond 'trial' sponsorships into deep, long-term integration with the Esports ecosystem.

On a more personal note, I am incredibly bullish on the completion of 'Cade Heights.' This infrastructure represents the next phase of our evolution. Having a dedicated space to execute our vision will allow us to scale our operations and provide a world-class environment for talent development and event execution.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

I predict three major shifts:

- *The 'Mainstream' Explosion: Gaming will move from a subculture to a pillar of mainstream Nigerian media, fueled by more consistent TV programming and celebrity involvement.*
- *Infrastructure-Led Growth: We will see a 'gigantic rise' in physical gaming events, moving from small hubs to stadium-scale experiences.*

***Global Representation:** 2026 will be the year Nigeria becomes a consistent exporter of talent. I expect to see Nigerian gamers not just participating, but podiuming at international tournaments, representing the green-white-green on the global stage.*

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in Nigeria in 2026?

- *Success in 2026 would be defined by Sustainability and Synergy. While we already see the momentum from global developers, a truly successful year would see the full integration of government policy with private sector innovation.*

- *When the government provides the 'enabling environment'—through high-speed internet infrastructure and tax incentives for tech-sports—and the private sector provides the content and talent, the entire sports industry wins. If we can solidify that partnership, 2026 will be the most successful year in our industry's history."*







SECTOR INSIGHT

PARTNERSHIPS & INVESTMENT

Introduction

Partnerships and investment represent a strategic and catalytic sector within the Nigerian sports industry, serving as financial and structural backbone for growth across events, leagues, grassroots development, and sports infrastructure. As public funding remains limited and institutional frameworks continue to evolve, private sector participation - through sponsorships, naming rights, equity investments, media rights deals - has become essential to unlocking scale and sustainability. Corporate-backed events and private owned sports properties illustrate how strategic collaborations can elevate brand visibility, professional standards, and economic impact. With Nigeria's large youth population, expanding digital consumption, and growing appetite for sports entertainment, partnership and investment activity is positioned to become a defining driver of innovation, commercialisation, and long-term value creation across the national sports ecosystem.

Panelists

Maxwell Kalu - Founder, Africa Warriors Fighting Championship

For us, we are gearing up to deliver our most busy schedule this year. AKO is continuing to push MMA and PFL will be entering Nigeria for the first time. 2026 is shaping up to be the best year for Nigerian combat sports on record.

01

Amobi Ezeaku - General Manager, Rangers International

I am most excited about the possibility of Nigerian football finally aligning passion with systems. I anticipate increased private-sector participation in club operations, sponsorship, and infrastructure development.

02

Funmilola Oyewole - MILO Sports Marketing Manager, Nestle

I expect to see stronger institutional support for structured grassroots platforms, deeper school-community collaborations, and clearer frameworks for measuring inclusion and long-term impact, not just participation. Brands will increasingly be evaluated on how well they democratise access to sport and contribute to sustainable talent pipelines

03

Maxwell Kalu

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

Announcing our partnership with DAZN and broadcasting our first event, The Dambe World Series, on the platform. This deal highlighted true global interest and investment in Dambe.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

Globally, the UFC signing a $7bn media rights deal which highlighted renewed global interest in combat sports. Locally, the E1 boat race was a highlight. It showcased that global partners are seeing Nigeria as a viable partner.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

The growth of combat sports. I believe it is the most promising space in sports now.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

For us, we are gearing up to deliver our most busy schedule this year. AKO is continuing to push MMA and PFL will be entering Nigeria for the first time. 2026 is shaping up to be the best year for Nigerian combat sports on record.

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in Nigeria in 2026?

More investment. More partnerships with corporates aiming to use sports to reach new audiences and sell products. Real commitment beyond just words from the Federal/State governments on supporting sports.





Amobi Ezeaku

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

For me, 2025 was defined by renewed belief in structure and institutional rebuilding within Nigerian football. At Rangers, we experienced firsthand how deliberate governance, professionalism, and long-term thinking can still yield results in a challenging environment.

Key highlights included:

- *The gradual re-emergence of clubs as institutions, not just matchday teams, with increased attention to academies, branding, and community engagement.*
- *Growing corporate confidence in football, evidenced by more meaningful sponsorship conversations driven by data, visibility, and credibility rather than sentiment.*
- *Youth football and school-based programs gaining traction, which aligns strongly with our Rangers Academicals and school orientation initiatives.*
- *Increased conversations around club sustainability, player trading models, and private sector participation, which signals maturity in the industry.*

Overall, 2025 reminded us that Nigerian sports—especially football—still has enormous upside if we stay patient with process.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

From a club administration and football management standpoint, 2025 was a year of validation and transition.

Defining moments included:

- *Rangers consolidating its identity as a professionally run club, not just a historically successful one.*
- *Stronger emphasis on compliance, licensing, and governance, driven by CAF, FIFA, and domestic league requirements.*
- *Player mobility and structured transfers, where Nigerian clubs began to negotiate with more confidence and foresight, including sell-on clauses and future value protection.*
- *Deeper engagement between clubs and State institutions, particularly legislatures and ministries, reflecting a growing understanding of football as a development and economic tool.*

For our sector, 2025 marked a shift from survival thinking to strategic planning.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

I am most excited about the possibility of Nigerian football finally aligning passion with systems.

Specifically:

- *The maturity of club leadership, with more administrators thinking beyond immediate results to legacy, infrastructure, and governance.*
- *Youth development becoming central, not cosmetic—academies, women's football, and grassroots structures gaining real investment.*
- *Commercial innovation, including digital fan engagement, merchandising, media content, and improved matchday experiences.*
- *The opportunity for clubs like Rangers to lead by example, showing that tradition and modernity can coexist.*

2026 presents a real chance for Nigerian football to begin telling a different story—one built on credibility.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

In 2026, I anticipate:

- *More Nigerian clubs executing structured player export strategies, with clear development pathways and contractual intelligence.*
- *Women's football moving from symbolic inclusion to real investment, including clearer ownership structures and competitive frameworks.*
- *Increased private-sector participation in club operations, sponsorship, and infrastructure development.*
- *Stronger regulatory enforcement, pushing clubs to professionalize or fall behind.*
- *Expanded focus on stadium experience, safety, and technology, including LED boards, ticketing systems, and volunteer/steward development.*

For club administrators, 2026 will likely reward competence, transparency, and patience more than ever before.

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

A successful 2026 would be one where:

- *Nigerian sports move closer to self-sustainability, with reduced dependence on emergency funding.*
- *Clubs are financially more disciplined, even if not yet wealthy.*
- *Youth and women's sports are institutionally protected, not personality driven.*
- *Fans return to stadiums consistently because they feel safe, respected, and valued.*
- *Administrators are judged less by noise and more by structure, impact, and continuity.*

Ultimately, success in 2026 would mean that Nigerian sports–especially football–takes another firm step away from improvisation and closer to intentional growth.



Funmilola Oyewole

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

One of the biggest highlights of 2025 was the growing recognition of long-term grassroots investment as the backbone of sports development. This was strongly reinforced by the 25th edition of the MILO Basketball Championship, which symbolised consistency, scale, and sustained impact in youth sports development across Nigeria.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

For sports marketing and development, 2025 was defining because brands moved from episodic sponsorships to legacy-building platforms. Celebrating the 25th MILO Basketball Championship, alongside initiatives like our MILO Building Champs, reaffirmed how purpose-led platforms can drive access, inclusion, and life skills development for children and youth across gender, geography, and ability levels.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

I am most excited about the increasing focus on inclusive grassroots sports ecosystems, where every child, regardless of background, has a pathway to participate. The alignment of sports with education and character development continues to gain momentum, an approach MILO has consistently championed for over three decades.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

In 2026, I expect to see stronger institutional support for structured grassroots platforms, deeper school–community collaborations, and clearer frameworks for measuring inclusion and long-term impact, not just participation. Brands will increasingly be evaluated on how well they democratise access to sport and contribute to sustainable talent pipelines.

I am also looking forward to accelerated investment in sports infrastructure, as Nigeria currently faces a significant facilities deficit that limits access to organised sports, particularly at the grassroots and school levels.

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

A successful 2026 would be one where inclusive access to organised sports significantly expands, school sports regain structural strength, and grassroots platforms clearly feed into national development pathways, ensuring sport truly serves as a teacher of values, resilience, and opportunity for every child.


MILO



SECTOR INSIGHT

BROADCAST & MEDIA

Introduction

Across the world, internet penetration, devices and platform are enabling the content creation, distribution and consumption. Over 720,000 hours of videos are uploaded every day on YouTube, with approximately 23 million videos created on TikTok daily.[1] Platforms like Facebook boasts of over 3.2bn users worldwide driving the content creation market[2]. Video accounts for 80% of all consumer internet traffic and is expected to account for over 60% of average daily time spent on social media[3]. Sport remains the purest form of live content and compelling storytelling. Sports in Africa is beginning to appreciate the importance of content creation on digital platforms. TotalEnergies CAF Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) Morocco 2025 set a record with 5.2bn video views across social media platforms, making it the most viewed football continental competition[4]. Nigeria with its 60% youth demography, 45-50% internet penetration and 64%-90% mobile connectivity can leverage digital-first content strategies to drive the development of the sports industry

Panelists

01

The sale of Multichoice to Canal Plus and its effect of broadcast of sport content will be a defining moment for the sports industry

-Felix Awogu - General Manager, SuperSport

02

I witnessed firsthand how deliberate, sustained coverage can reshape public perception and commercial interest. The Super Falcons' WAFCON campaign, supported by consistent nationwide media storytelling, fundamentally changed the narrative around women's football in Nigeria.

- **Debbie Izamoje-Okolie - CEO, Brila Media**

03

I believe Nigerian sport will move from "reactive storytelling" to "intentional storytelling." Instead of waiting for controversy or victory, we'll proactively build legacy-driven projects – documentaries, athlete-led platforms, data-driven analysis, and community-backed content.

- Lanre Aina - Founder/CEO, ATHLST

Felix Awogu

1. What were the key highlights for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

The creation of the National Sport commission

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

The sale of Multichoice to Canal Plus and its effect of broadcast of sport content

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

How the Super Eagles perform at [the] Afcon

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

Government and National Broadcasting Commission Policy on Sport Rights

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

If a league team wins a continental trophy



Debbie Izamoje-Okolie

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

2025 was a defining year for Nigerian sports, particularly in how excellence, resilience, and national belief came together across different disciplines.

In football, the Super Falcons' historic 10th Women's Africa Cup of Nations title in Morocco stood out not just for the trophy, but for the journey. Coming back from two goals down to defeat the host nation 3–2 in the final captured the very essence of Nigerian resilience. Beyond the result, the tournament symbolised what happens when a nation truly rallies behind its athletes, despite pre-tournament challenges, administrative distractions, and doubts surrounding a domestically appointed coach. It was a victory powered by belief, unity, and character.

In basketball, D'Tigress reinforced Nigeria's dominance on the continent by winning an unprecedented fifth consecutive Women's AfroBasket title. Overcoming Mali in the final, they surpassed Senegal's long-standing record and etched their names into history as the first team to win the championship five times in a row. The triumph also secured Nigeria automatic qualification for the FIBA Women's World Cup, further affirming the country's growing stature in global women's basketball.

Para-sports also delivered exceptional moments. Para-Olympic medalist Bolaji Eniola had an extraordinary year, reaching six finals and winning five gold medals across international tournaments. Her consistency and dominance underscored the depth of talent Nigeria continues to produce when opportunity and visibility meet support.

In cricket, the Junior Female Yellow-Greens made history by representing Nigeria for the first time at the ICC Women's T20 World Cup in Malaysia. Finishing sixth overall and earning automatic qualification for the 2027 edition in Bangladesh marked a major milestone for a sport that continues to grow quietly but steadily in Nigeria.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

For sports media and advocacy, 2025 was a year defined by intention and alignment. As CEO of Brila Media, I witnessed firsthand how deliberate, sustained coverage can reshape public perception and commercial interest. The Super Falcons' WAFCON campaign, supported by consistent nationwide media storytelling, fundamentally changed the narrative around women's football in Nigeria.

For the first time, the team enjoyed sustained mainstream visibility across radio, digital, and on-ground fan engagement platforms. This translated into unprecedented public support and, crucially, renewed brand confidence. As media attention intensified, brands followed, creating more commercial opportunities than we had seen around previous major tournaments, including the Olympics and the Women's World Cup.
The sight of fans filling stadiums to support the women was not accidental. It was the outcome of access, advocacy, and storytelling done with purpose. Winning the trophy was the culmination of that process and marked a defining moment for sports media in Nigeria ,proof that when value is communicated consistently, engagement and investment follow.

3. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector or service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

Looking ahead to 2026, I am most excited by the momentum created by the Super Falcons' success and the new expectations it has set for women's football in Nigeria.

There is a real opportunity to consolidate this progress through sustained performance, deeper fan engagement, and long-term brand partnerships. From a media perspective,

the challenge and opportunity is to ensure the conversation does not revert to event-based interest but evolves into year-round engagement.

Beyond competition, the forthcoming Nigerian Football Federation elections are also critical. Leadership decisions taken in this period will shape the structure, credibility, and growth of Nigerian football over the next four years, with direct implications for how the sport is covered, commercialised, and trusted by stakeholders.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

Media attention in early 2026 is likely to be driven by the Super Eagles' performance at the Africa Cup of Nations in Morocco. A strong run, particularly a title win would dominate sports coverage, re-energise fans, and significantly boost brand interest and commercial activity.

Similarly, the Super Falcons' next WAFCON campaign is expected to attract even stronger media focus and increased private-sector investment. The shift is already evident: women's sports are no longer treated as side narratives but as central assets within the sports ecosystem, capable of driving engagement, revenue, and national pride.

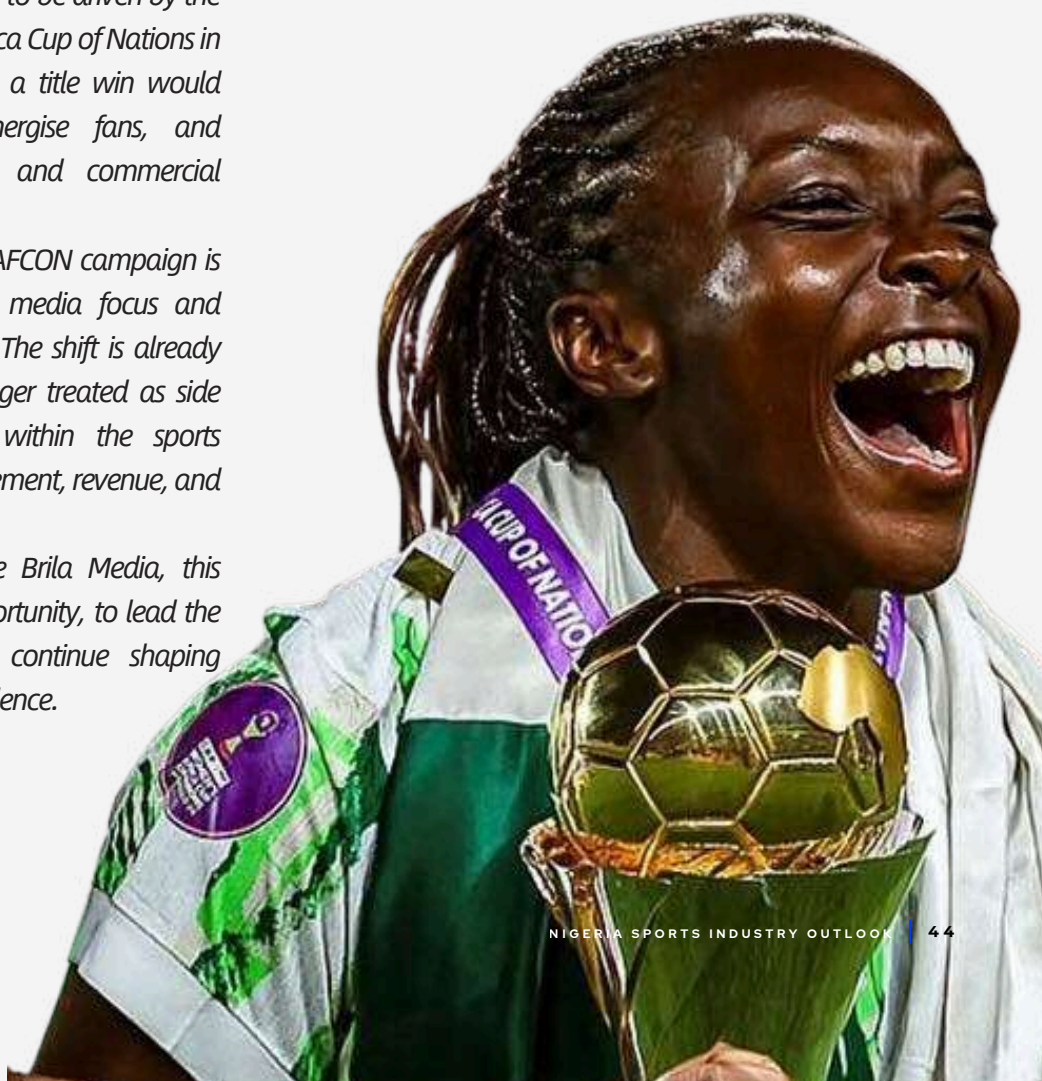
For sports media organisations like Brila Media, this presents both responsibility and opportunity, to lead the conversation, set standards, and continue shaping narratives that reflect value and excellence.

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

For a sports-participating nation of Nigeria's stature, success is ultimately measured by excellence on the field of play. A truly successful year would be one in which Nigerian athletes consistently compete for – and win – gold medals across major competitions.

Beyond medals, success would also be reflected in stronger systems that support performance: improved preparation, credible administration, sustained media engagement, and increased private-sector confidence.

When winning becomes the standard rather than the exception, and when athletes are supported by strong institutions and responsible storytelling, it signals that the sports industry is not just active – it is thriving



Lanre Aina

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

For me, 2025 was the year Nigerian sport began exercising real, measurable soft power globally – not just through wins, but through influence. Take football, for example, Nigerian players were central to major European storylines – from headline transfers that reshaped club ambitions to decisive performances in title races and continental competitions. They drove global media cycles and fan engagement numbers.

In athletics, Nigerian sprinters and hurdlers consistently featured in Diamond League headlines and global championships, keeping Nigeria in elite-track conversations year-round. Beyond times and medals, their presence in post-race interviews, social media, and brand campaigns extended Nigeria's visibility far beyond the track.

In combat sports, Nigerian-born champions continued to command pay-per-view main events and global press tours, projecting Nigerian identity onto some of the biggest sporting stages in the world. Even at the youth and women's levels, Nigerian teams generated viral moments that dominated international feeds – not just for results, but for celebration culture, confidence, and style.

The shift in 2025 was clear: Nigerian athletes weren't just representing the country; they were shaping global sports culture in real time.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

For sports media and storytelling, 2025 was defining in several ways:

Athlete-controlled narratives after controversy: When elite Nigerian athletes faced transfer sagas, federation disputes, or eligibility debates in 2025, the story no longer broke first on traditional TV. It broke on Instagram Live, X (Twitter), or via personal statements.

- *That shift – from journalist-controlled framing to athlete-first framing is a watershed moment.*
- *The Explosion of Digital-First Sports Shows: Independent YouTube and podcast platforms covering AFCON qualifiers, transfer windows, and Olympic build-ups saw significant growth in engagement. Shows featuring former Super Eagles players consistently trended on Nigerian YouTube sports charts during major matchdays. Instead of waiting for traditional TV analysis, fans turned to long-form digital conversations for context and unfiltered takes. That shift in consumption – from broadcast-first to digital-first has become the norm.*
- *Viral micro-moments driving global visibility: In 2025, short-form sports storytelling became a powerful currency. Celebration clips, locker-room footage, player tunnel interactions, and post-match soundbites from Nigerian athletes routinely crossed into global football and sports pages. A single 30-second clip could generate millions of impressions – something that previously required full match broadcasts.*
- *Brand integration moving from logo placement to storytelling: We saw more Nigerian athletes fronting campaigns that told personal stories – not just wearing kits or appearing in static billboards. Brands leaned into origin stories, training routines, and lifestyle narratives. The athlete was positioned as a character, not just an endorser. This evolution signals maturity in sports storytelling – and a growing understanding that story drives commercial value.*
- *Global distribution interest in Nigerian sports IP: There was an increasing international appetite for African sports stories – from scouting documentaries to behind-the-scenes football features. Conversations about licensing, streaming distribution, and cross-border collaborations became more common.*

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

I'm most excited about narrative maturity, as live-sports licensing continues to be highly contested. We're betting on the emergence of sports-adjacent programming.

In 2026, I believe Nigerian sport will move from "reactive storytelling" to "intentional storytelling." Instead of waiting for controversy or victory, we'll proactively build legacy-driven projects – documentaries, athlete-led platforms, data-driven analysis, and community-backed content.

I'm especially excited about the convergence of sport and technology. AI-powered tools are rapidly lowering the cost of high-quality production – from editing and sound design to data visualization and distribution – making it possible to tell ambitious, archive-heavy, or analytically complex sports stories that would previously have been financially out of reach.

What once required large crews and broadcast-level budgets can now be developed leaner, faster, and with greater creative precision. That shift doesn't just improve efficiency – it expands the kind of stories we can realistically bring to life.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area in 2026?

I see four major shifts:

- ***Athlete-to-IP pipeline expansion.*** *- More Nigerian athletes will transition into structured content ventures – podcasts, documentaries, and equity-backed media projects.*
- ***International distribution deals for Nigerian sports content.*** *- We will see at least one Nigerian sports documentary or long-form project secure meaningful global distribution.*
- ***Stronger brand-athlete-content integration*** *- Brand partnerships will evolve from logo placements to story-driven integrations aligned with purpose and identity.*
- ***Monetization innovation.*** *- Subscription-based, community-backed, and hybrid funding models will gain traction, proving that Nigerian sports storytelling can be commercially sustainable.*

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

A successful 2026 would mean:

- *Improved infrastructure and athlete support systems.*
- *Transparent governance and stronger federation credibility.*
- *At least one globally resonant sporting moment that unites the country.*
- *Sustainable commercial models for leagues and athletes.*
- *Exportable media intellectual property – not just exported talent.*

Ultimately, success in 2026 will not just be measured in medals, but in systems built, stories preserved, and global respect earned.





SECTOR INSIGHT

LICENSING, INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY (IP) AND MERCHANDISING

Introduction

The commercialization of sports is built on our ability to create and market sports products. The size of the global sporting goods market is currently valued at $612bn and projected to reached approximately $1.35tn by 2035[1]. Nigeria has struggled with the creation, marketing and distribution of sport products, one of which is apparel and merchandised. But organisations are emerging to change this. Underpinning the success of the creation of sport products is the understanding of intellectual property – what qualifies as such and who owns the rights; licensing and transfer of IP rights; and merchandising – the creation of products from licensed rights.

Panelists

01	**Olufunbi Falayi, Seon Sports**	Experiencing the Nigeria Rugby League female team wearing a locally designed and manufactured sports apparel in their first World Series Qualifiers in Canada was one of my key highlights for 2025
02	**Rita Anwiri Chindah, IP Consultant**	There is growing recognition that sports are intellectual property driven and the athletes are commercial assets. Therefore, leagues in Nigeria must be run as business entities, not social programmes
03	**Olamide Adeyemo, Sporting Lagos**	Commercial viability of sports enterprises - clubs, associations and even players – from strong brand building and partnerships, and the exploration of proven marketable channels like digital will deliver a successful year for sports in Nigeria
04	**Adedammy Adedotun, Fancified**	The young demography is growing in the country and are becoming upwardly mobile. I am excited at the possibility of having sport entertainment products to cater to these young people
05	**Adebayo 'Pooja' Sulaiman.**	For the first time, I designed a jersey, and it got good reviews, good acceptance and good sales as well. That's obviously one of the key moments for me

Olufunbi Falayi

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

Séon is a sports apparel company, and we saw a big shift in sports teams making enquiries about high quality jerseys. This is a far cry from when we first launched in 2024. This could lead to the evolution of the industry as we continue to push for fabrics that fit the weather conditions and expected quality from sport teams.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

Experiencing the Nigeria Rugby League female team wearing a locally designed and manufactured sports apparel in their first World Series Qualifiers in Canada. The highlights were the attraction and the commendation garnered from other teams and organizers. We expect to see more teams embrace local brands.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigeria sports industry in 2026?

We expect to see more teams in the Nigeria football, basketball, Volleyball and Rugby professional leagues wear locally designed and produced sport apparels.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

N/A

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

More teams and federations patronizing local sport brands.



Rita Anwiri Chindah

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

Aside the few wins we had from the athletes and the pockets of progress in grassroots football and private sponsorships, nothing stood out as transformative enough to shift the trajectory of Nigerian sports.

Also, the continued resilience of private sector driven sports initiatives, academies, leagues, and athlete representation models operating despite limited government intervention. This confirmed what many of us already know: the future of Nigerian sports growth is increasingly private led, not state dependent.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

- *More athletes began seeking legal guidance on contracts, image rights, and dispute resolution.*
- *Growing interest in sports law education. For instance, the Rivers State University introduced sports law as an elective course for law students into curricula, reflecting the sector's gradual recognition. Then there is the Business of Sports Institute by Mrs Beverley Onyejianya-Agbakoba which has an all-round sports curriculum for sports practitioners.*
- *Regulatory Conversations: Discussions around governance, anti-doping compliance, and dispute resolution mechanisms gained traction, even if not yet fully implemented.*

3. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector or service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

- *First the potential for structural reforms. There is growing pressure on federations and clubs to adopt better governance practices, and I anticipate more athletes and stakeholders embracing legal literacy.*
- *The rise of digital platforms for sports management and media rights for instance requires a similar model of the Netflix & FIFA collaboration and athlete branding also presents opportunities for lawyers and educators to play a bigger role.*
- *There is growing recognition that sports are intellectual property driven and the athletes are commercial assets. Therefore, leagues in Nigeria must be run as business entities, not social programmes*

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

- *An increase in sponsorship deals for Nigerian athletes, more awareness for athletes with disabilities, image rights commercialization and media rights negotiations which will require legal insights, thereby creating more demand for specialized expertise from relevant experts.*
- *Heightened scrutiny of sports federations' governance structures, especially where public funds and private sponsorship intersect*
- *Greater reliance on local and international arbitration bodies for dispute resolution.*
- *Expansion of the esports games in Nigeria*
- *More Nigerian athletes demanding standardised contracts and professional representation*
- *Maybe an adaptation of AI by private sector led sports entities*

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

My theme for 2026 is "The year of alignment" and these are what I think would make the Nigerian sports industry a success:

- *We need clearer policies and accountability in sports federations.*
- *We need to take athletes' welfare seriously by implementing contract enforcement, health insurance, and career transition support.*
- *Tangible investments in training facilities and stadiums not the disgrace we experienced few months ago*
- *Nigerian athletes and teams performing credibly on the global stage, and investment in our media teams to tell a positive story of the sector*
- *The recognition of sports law as a critical pillar of the ecosystem, with more structured training for stakeholders.*
- *Emphasized need for increased use of legal, financial, and intellectual property advisory services within sports organisations.*



Olamide Adeyemo

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

- *A private club, Remo Stars winning the NPFL signals what is right with our football. That private clubs can compete and the readiness of the nation for more private ownership*
- *The Super Falcons clinching their 10th Women's Africa Cup of Nations (WAFCON)*
- *D'Tigress winning their fifth consecutive FIBA Women's AfroBasket*

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

- *Nigeria missing out of the 2026 world cup is beyond patriotism, it is a dark marker on the entire sports marketing industry as brand activations, content/campaigns and media buying already can count the losses in millions of dollars.*
- *Poor officiating deprived some deserving football clubs advancement and marketing earnings. The blatantness of bias and/or the incompetence of match officials remains a bitter pill to swallow across all echelons of professional football*

3. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector or service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

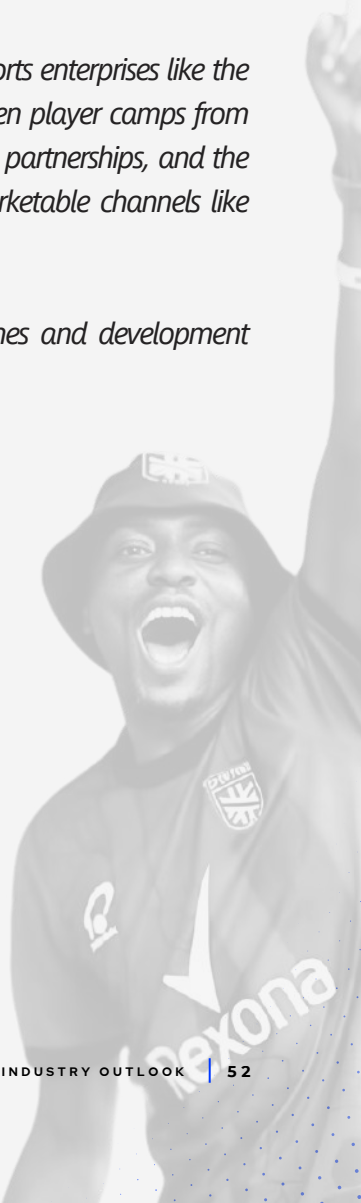
- *Heightened interest in national football owing to a great AFCON performance, despite the world cup qualification failure*
- *The growing development of women's sports in football and basketball especially*
- *Collegiate sports development with initiatives such as Monieball and Varsity Cup*

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

- *More private club success in the NNL especially*
- *An increased participation of private football clubs across the country*
- *Bigger awareness for women's sports - basketball and football*
- *Emerging sports such as flag football and esports will get bigger*

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

- *Prioritization of meritocracy across sports on and off the field - players, administrators, match and team officials etc*
- *Commercial viability of sports enterprises like the clubs, associations and even player camps from strong brand building and partnerships, and the exploration of proven marketable channels like digital*
- *Grassroots talent focus*
- *Infrastructure - more pitches and development outlets*



Adedamilola Adedotun

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

The major highlight for me in 2025 was the Sports Africa Investment Summit organised by Sport Nigeria. A first of its kind within the sport industry. The event brought together professionals within and outside the sports industry to discuss strategies to drive the required investment into sports and the conversation were very insightful.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

Two moments stood out for me in the fan engagement + merchandising space in 2025. One was Sulaiman "Pooja' Adebayo launching his special Pooja jerseys. It was the first time within the industry that a media personality (non-athlete) will leverage his/her brand and popularity to create apparel for sale. The second was the publishing of Elusive – a story of Enyimba's consecutive champion's league victory – by Solace Chukwu. Stories help connect fans to their clubs and it was good to see the story of such historic feat told. We, at Fancified, are proud to be distribution partners to both Pooja and Solace Chukwu.

3. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector or service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

The young demography is growing in the country and are becoming upwardly mobile. I am excited at the possibility of having sport entertainment products to cater to these young people. I am also excited about the endless possibilities for tech-driven fan engagement.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

I predict that we'll have more private-owned tournaments and events, and fan engagement, through merchandising, will be part of their growth strategy. I predict that National Federation – outside football and basketball – will enter licensing deals with kit manufacturers and will sell replicas to fans as a way of driving fan engagement and brand association. I predict that sports apparel and fashion will play a significant role in connecting young people to sports than sporting events. I predict that there will be more synergy between tech and sports.

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

Peaceful, non-disruptive elections and change in leadership at National Federations within the country. Emergence of more provide owned professional tournaments, competitions and teams.



Sulaiman Adebayo

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

The major highlights are to be the World Cup playoffs, securing the World Cup playoff ticket from the group for going to Morocco and eventually not winning it. AFCON was also a major highlight, although extended to 2026. We played one of our best football at the tournament. Another highlight is the players getting their reward for the silver they won at 2023 AFCON Côte d'Ivoire - the National Awards, the lands and the houses promised.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/services area in 2025?

There were lots of defining moments from photojournalism, and of course, merchandising. For the first time, I designed a jersey, and it got good reviews, good acceptance and good sales as well. That's obviously one of the key moments. Photojournalism is huge now, you know. All events across board want to have a photojournalist, a photographer who comes around to document their event and tell their story.

3. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector or service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

I like what we are achieving with the National Sports Festival. We are now participating in several competitions that are not only football. We went to Saudi Arabia for the Islamic games, and we also had a good outing in Algeria for the Secondary School Games.

We are participating in all these other competitions and there is the Commonwealth Games this year, 2026. We have done well at the Commonwealth Games in previous years. So, I look forward to how Nigeria and the athletes will perform this year. AFCON qualifiers to start as well this year too. Tanzania, Uganda and Kenya hosting it for 2026.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

For Pooja Media, there are lots of stuff coming on board. There'll be more outfits. We will see more brands coming on board to design their own kind of jerseys for sales. The Commonwealth Games will also standout because it connects every other sport, not only football. It would be a big one.

Based on the verdict from FIFA, if FIFA rules against the DR Congo for the World Cup ticket, that could be a major event in 2026.

5. What would mark as a successful year for the general sports industry in 2026?

- *I think number one would be for our sports to be respected from local to international and for the NPFL to return to mainstream television.*
- *For the National Stadium in Abuja to be renovated like the NSC announced so we won't have all our football games in Akwa Ibom. That way, we will have another standard FIFA-approved stadium. So that if other NPFL club qualify for the continental tournaments, they can play in Abuja*
- *And overall, sports journalists should have, more gigs.*



SECTOR INSIGHT

SPORTS INFRASTRUCTURE

Introduction

Sports infrastructure sits at the centre of industry formation and expansion in Nigeria. Modern stadiums, training centres, and community-level facilities are not merely venues for competition; they anchor talent identification systems, enable broadcast-standard competitions, stimulate sports commerce, and support ancillary value chains spanning media, sponsorship, hospitality, and retail. Where infrastructure is limited, poorly maintained, or geographically concentrated, industry growth becomes uneven and commercially constrained. Equitable access—across regions, genders, and income groups—is therefore not a social add-on but an economic imperative. Broad-based facility development expands the talent pool, increases participation rates, strengthens league structures, and deepens fan markets, ultimately improving the investability of the sector. A deliberate infrastructure strategy that combines rehabilitation of flagship assets with scalable community sports hubs will be critical to unlocking sustainable industry-wide growth.

Panelists

01

Carven gives players a place to grow. Players have [a] structured space(s) to train, compete, and build community. Carven changed everything, it moves esports from informal play to a performance environment. This proves that strong events and strong infrastructures gives the esports industry a great shape

- Damilola Pedro - COO, Carven by Gamr

02

The key to using sports events as a revenue generating medium and publicity platform for sponsors is transforming the venue - through quality infrastructure and equipment - to be worthy of hosting the event and meeting the brands expectations.

- Babalola Opeyemi - CEO, Webber Hoops & Engineering

Damilola Pedro

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

When I look at 2025, what stands out is how far esports have come from an events and infrastructure standpoints.

On infrastructure, Carven is playing a central role. Access has always been one of the biggest barriers in esports. Now, players have structured spaces to train, compete, and build community. Carven changed everything, it moves esports from informal play to a performance environment. This proves that strong events and strong infrastructures gives the esports industry a great shape.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

There was a defining moment when hubs like Carven became central to the ecosystem, giving players the tools to perform at higher levels. We opened doors to accessible platforms and opportunities for players and creators to get support, giving more players across the country a chance to compete and develop their skills.

Funding and policy will be major defining factors this year. We want to see more structured conversations around investments, regulations, and recognitions. Government interest is increasing, and that gives the sector stability.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

The reach and growth.
Carven is giving players a place to grow. GamrX gives them a stage to prove themselves. When both exist side by side, talent develops faster and performs better. And with more exposure, more support, and better infrastructure

I think we're going to see a lot of stories of Nigerian talents making waves both here and globally. Gamrx and other platforms, describes this reach and growth as not just national anymore, it's now global. I'm excited that players who previously had no access to professional setups can now practice properly and grow their skills. That combination of exposure and resources is what will take Nigerian esports to the next level.



4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

You'll see Carven-style infrastructure expand and become part of how players train and prepare. Not a luxury. A standard. And with events like GamrX reaching a five-year milestone signalling maturity. Longevity in this space means credibility. It shows the ecosystem can sustain itself and keep growing.

I feel like 2026 is the year that momentum really builds up, predicting the expansion of esports infrastructure into underserved regions, the launch of formal talent development programs, and wider digital and broadcast coverage so fans across Nigeria can engage with competitions live.



5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in Nigeria in 2026?

A successful year is when participation rises and performance improves at the same time.

When athletes have places to train at every region in Nigeria.
When funding becomes more structured.
When policies support growth instead of slowing it down.
When Nigerian players are visible and respected beyond our borders.
When national events like GamrX are consistent and well attended.

A successful year would be one where participation grows, not just in numbers but in quality. Events run smoothly and draw global attention. Hubs and infrastructure are accessible and help develop talent consistently.

The challenges are no longer about proving esports deserves a seat at the table. That conversation has moved. Now it's about scale, it's about standards, and global competitiveness. And with platforms like GamrX and infrastructure like Carven driving the progress, the industry is operating with more clarity, more credibility, and stronger direction than ever before.



Babalola Opeyemi

1. What were the key highlight(s) for you in the Nigerian sports industry in 2025?

There is a new drive to use sports events both as a revenue generating medium and publicity for sponsors. The key is transforming the venue to be worthy of hosting the event and meeting the brands' standards / expectations. There must be some form of fan engagement during the events that keeps them wanting more; hence we introduced a dunk team performance.

2. What were the defining moments for your sector/ service area in 2025?

The overall defining moments for me was the visibility that the Webber brand got by providing infrastructure and equipment for events, both the events we hosted and the ones we collaborated with event organisers.

3. What are you most excited about in the Nigerian sports industry in 2026?

I am excited about the opportunity to build more on the success of 2025 and instilling in the minds of prospects the attitude of running sports as a business and not charity.

4. What specific milestones, events, or shifts do you predict will stand out in your sector/service area of the Nigerian sports ecosystem in 2026?

The 2026 edition of the National Sports Festival will stand out in 2026 as Enugu State continues to prepare to host the rest of the country later this year. Election at the National Sports Federation to vote in new leadership and Board members will have significant consequences this year.

5. What would mark a successful year for the general sports industry in Nigeria in 2026?

2026 would be marked as successful if there is a noticeable increase in the total revenue generated from sports as a business.





EXPERTS OPINION

EXPERIENCE-DRIVEN MARKET

Tonte Davies
Founder/CEO, Rapids Sports and Entertainment

For over a year, I have become an ardent consumer of live and non-live video content on YouTube which border on sports (including game highlights); entertainment such as music videos, skits, Hollywood trailers, and Nollywood movies; documentaries; business & innovation; knowledge & education; and news.

The near infinite amount of content existent on YouTube is both fascinating and mind-blowing! In fact, YouTube has become for me a daily go-to depending on what I deliberately search for or what the algorithm throws at me based on my search patterns and behaviour. One of my experiences with video content on YouTube in 2025, was keeping up with the debut and live stream of E1 Lagos GP in Nigeria which raced its way across the Lagos lagoon garnering over 120,000 views on all contents combined.

Apparently, the data does not include viewer numbers on SuperSport Nigeria or its Africa-wide affiliates. And we will increasingly witness and experience even more live (and shared) sports-related content on the video-sharing platform in 2026, with monetization as a vital strategy considering the not-so-mature broadcast rights market in Nigeria.

As it enters its second season in 2026, the E1 Lagos GP is likely to see increased number of fans because of its perceptively elitist and destination market appeal, visibility and sustainability mission. By the same token, and besides being targeted, the sports events space will witness increased following among younger demographics based on the experience and community-driven impact. This simply implies that expectations of sports events in Nigeria will go beyond just the sporting element with emphasis on buzz, experience, and community impact. There are chances that we will see new events in cycling, tennis, and volleyball. From an organiser point of view, revenue models will continue to be tested based on the nature and appeal of not just the sports but the sports event as a product & IP, and its ability to target younger demographics. However, sustainability will depend on better planning, data-driven marketing, and improved safety and logistics standards.

Attracting investments into and across critical components of the value chain of the sports industry remains a major talking point among industry leaders and practitioners. Although investment opportunities exist, the industry is yet to, like its siblings in entertainment [music, movies and theatre] demonstrate commercial viability for institutional investment and business leaders. Investments are required to flow in the direction of infrastructure such as venues and arenas, events, broadcast media, and competitions. Unfortunately, this is not the case. Borrowing from the Nigerian music industry, Mavin Records was able to attract external investment because it built both strong internal organisational structure and marketable products (artistes) that both Nigerians and international markets were willing to pay for and consume, proving demonstrable demand and returns. To attract investment, existing and new sports organisations & properties will work to build strong internal structure to develop sporting IP and sports products.

Partnerships will remain a key growth driver for Nigeria's sports industry in 2026, with increasing alignment between sports properties, corporate Nigeria, industry players, and government. Corporate partnerships with leagues, events, and athletes have become more value-driven and will continue in this direction. The partnership will shift from one-off sponsorships to longer-term brand activations focused on youth engagement, community impact, and measurable returns. Within the sports ecosystem, collaborations between event promoters, broadcasters, merchandisers, and service providers will become front burner conversations and, in some quarters, deepen. These collaborations will be driven by the need to share risk, reduce costs, and scale audiences. Strategic alliances and co-creation models will be critical for unlocking new revenue streams across content, data, and fan experiences. Clearer frameworks and mutual accountability will be essential for the government to attract sustainable private sector participation in 2026 and beyond.

Overall, 2026 presents a transition year: from passion-led sports to performance-driven sports business. Stakeholders who prioritise professionalism, partnerships, and scalable models will be best positioned to win.

FEDERATION BUSINESS TRANSFORMATION

Telema Davies
Managing Partner, DMPartners.

For the sports industry to experience real growth and transformation, adherence to the highest professional and ethical standards must be at the core of reforms meaningful to the development of the industry. While fan engagement, commercial growth, and technological innovation are critical accelerators, the sustainability of the sector hinges significantly on the effectiveness of national sports federations.

Administrative Reforms and Digital Transformation
National sports federations are under increasing pressure to operate with transparency, accountability, and operational efficiency. However, reform is not just about updating policies or forming committees–it requires the adoption of digital solutions to streamline processes, enforce compliance, and drive change management. Tools such as automated financial management systems, centralized athlete databases, and performance analytics platforms enable federations to:

- Implement reforms efficiently and measurably.
- Facilitate smooth change management across departments and stakeholders.
- Ensure accurate reporting and accountability to sponsors, regulators, and the public.
- Track performance metrics and outcomes for continuous improvement.

By integrating digital transformation into their operations, federations can modernize their administrative functions and position themselves as agile, forward-thinking organizations capable of meeting the demands of a rapidly evolving sports ecosystem.

Opportunities in 2026
Federations that embrace purposeful reforms and digital adoption unlock significant opportunities:

1. **Financial Sustainability:** Streamlined operations reduce inefficiencies and optimize resource allocation, making federations more attractive to sponsors and investors.
2. **Global Competitiveness:** Data-driven talent development enhances athlete performance, ensuring teams are competitive on international stages.
3. **Stakeholder Trust:** Transparent processes strengthen credibility with fans, athletes, sponsors, and regulatory bodies.
4. **Innovation Adoption:** Digital tools support new revenue streams, hybrid event models, and immersive fan engagement initiatives, reinforcing the industry's growth trajectory.

Risks of Non-Compliance
Conversely, federations that resist reform or fail to integrate digital solutions face tangible risks:

1. **Financial Mismanagement:** Inefficient, opaque processes deter sponsorship and investment.
2. **Reputation Damage:** Lack of transparency undermines public and stakeholder confidence.
3. **Stunted Growth:** Limited adoption of digital tools constrains innovation and competitiveness.
4. **Regulatory Intervention:** In the absence of internal governance, governments or international governing bodies may impose sanctions or enforce restructuring measures.

Forward-Looking Insight
The sports industry in 2026 presents unparalleled opportunities, yet the pathway to sustainable growth is inseparable from governance excellence, change management, and digital transformation. Federations that align operations with modern business principles and adopt technological innovations will not only secure financial stability but also drive engagement, enhance performance, and solidify global competitiveness. On the other hand, federations that fail to act risk obsolescence and missed opportunities in an increasingly digital and dynamic industry.

Purposeful reform is no longer optional–it is imperative for federations seeking to lead, innovate, and shape the future of sports. 2026 is the year for action, accountability, and transformation in the sports industry.

DIGITAL-FIRST, FAN-FOCUSED

Adedamilola Adedotun
Head of Sports, The Temple Company

Over 5,000 people watched the championship game of the Nigerian Premier Basketball League (PBL) between Lagos Legends and defending champions – Rivers Hoopers, live on One Sport's YouTube channel. Basketball is arguably the second most popular sport in Nigeria, and it was refreshing to see such major traditional sports leverage streaming of live sports on YouTube. In developed sports markets, media rights are the primary revenue driver of sports leagues, often delivering 30%-40% of revenue. In some cases, as much as 60%. Since we do not have a mature/existing media rights market for sporting events in Nigeria, YouTube streaming offers an alternative source of revenue generation, content promotion and audience building for sport properties. I predict that, this year, more sports properties will adopt a digital-first strategy, starting with YouTube streaming, to promote their events, monetize their content, reach a younger audience, gather and manage data. As we have seen in Nollywood, where YouTube has become a tool for growth, the success of filmmakers on YouTube has triggered the emergence of many other producers of full-length movies and series.

I predict that more private-owned sports properties – leagues, tournament and competitions, will emerge, targeting the younger demographics, creating an experience and using digital platforms for distribution and monetization. This is already happening with sports like Flag Football (Showtime Flag), traditional wrestling (Dambe Warriors, African Warriors Fighting Championship) etc. We should witness more of these in other sports like tennis, volleyball, futsal. Their emergence will create new entertainment experience in sports, bring in new fans and create an opportunity to promote fan-centric products and to monetize fan engagement.

My investment thesis in sports in Nigeria is that there are investment opportunities in infrastructure, events and tournaments, and ancillary services – media, tech etc. However, the investment landscape in Nigeria seem to favour demonstrated demand. We continue see investments in sports (football) talent development as there is a proven demand for young talents in football leagues outside the country. Health and lifestyle consciousness has triggered mass participation in fitness, resulting in increased investment in fitness chains like iFitness. My prediction is that, as more private-owned events emerge in the year and through their digital-first and fan-experience strategies, the demand for sports products will be demonstrated. Hence, attracting the right capital for expansion of the events and in the much-needed sports infrastructure. Properties like the African Warriors Fighting Championship and organisations like Gamr have attracted investment to drive their respective events in Nigeria. We should see more of this.

The investment in sports infrastructure is critical due to the huge infrastructure deficit in Nigeria and as we continue to advocate private investment in sports infrastructure, I predict that optimizing and outgrowing existing sporting infrastructure will become our most effective strategy for attracting investment. It demonstrates clear demand, generates immediate revenue, and reduces the perceived risks for private investors.

From content distribution to events and competition, to investment in events and ultimately infrastructure, this digital-first, fan-focused approach can drive the transformation of the sports industry in Nigeria. It is a methodical approach on which the pillars of the business of sports in Nigeria can be built. I look forward to the adoption of this approach starting from this year.

EXPERTS



Tonte Davies
Founder/CEO, Rapids Sports and Entertainment

Tonte Davies is the Founder and President/CEO of Rapids Sports and Entertainment Limited. He drives the strategic development and execution of initiatives that create engaging experiences, strengthen community participation, and unlock cross-sector value through sports and live events. His role also extends to policy-making and strategic decisions within the industry, where he contributes insights that shape how sports, entertainment, tourism, and hospitality intersect to drive sustainable development.



Telema Davies
Managing Partner, DMPartners.

Telema Davies is Co-Founder and Managing Partner of DMPartners. He has over 15 years of experience leading and collaborating in the sports industry across business management, operational strategy and consulting practice with expertise in market analysis; business development; policy framework design and formulation; development analysis; strategic partnerships and stakeholder management.



Adedamilola Adedotun
Head of Sports, The Temple Company

Adedamilola Adedotun has experience spanning close to two decades in consulting, strategic management, business development with a focus on the business of sports. He co-founded Mêtis Craton, a consulting practice focused on driving commercial growth across industries. He founded BballNaija, a media platform promoting basketball in Nigeria; and Fancified, a tech-enabled platform addressing the key touchpoints of every sports fan starting with merchandise/apparel. He is currently the Head of Sports at The Temple Company.

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Africa Warriors Fighting Championship
Rangers International
Webber Hoops
Pooja Media
Seon Sports
Sporting Lagos
Remo Stars SC
PH City Women Run

RAPIDS
SPORTS + ENTERTAINMENT

Rapids Sports and Entertainment (RSE) is a pioneering, innovative and family-focused sports, media and entertainment company.

dmpartners

DMPartners is a professional services firm specialising in the sports industry and adjacent markets.

Mêtis Craton

Mêtis Craton is a strategic advisory and innovation practice that provides insight-driven solutions for sustainable growth.